

Methodist University's Edwin L. Cox School of Business, did a five-year study of 550 households in Buffalo, New York, that suggested the psychological benefits of coupon clipping outweighed even the savings incentives. The results suggested that the very act of clipping was part of the fun. The respondents enjoyed the whole process.

But what about those instances when using coupons makes the consumer feel something less enjoyable, like embarrassment or as an annoyance to the cashier?

A recent study published in the *Journal of Retailing* shows an interesting reason why upper-income whites make far more use of coupons than members of minorities of all income levels. One surprising finding of this study, conducted by Anne Brumbaugh of the College of Charleston and Jose Antonio Rosa of the University of Wyoming, was how much the attitude of the cashier can determine the customer's willingness to use coupons.

A clerk's conscious or subconscious cues such as eye rolls, deep sighs, and terse movements in accepting the coupons can discourage all but the most confident from using them. Conversely, a clerk who implies that the customer is shrewd in their savings can inspire the customer to use them more often.

The study also investigated the reason why even the more affluent members of racial minorities don't often use coupons. They found that a consistent level of poor services experienced by high socioeconomic status black and Latino customers reduced their coupon use by decreasing their confidence and increasing their embarrassment over using them. Well-to-do